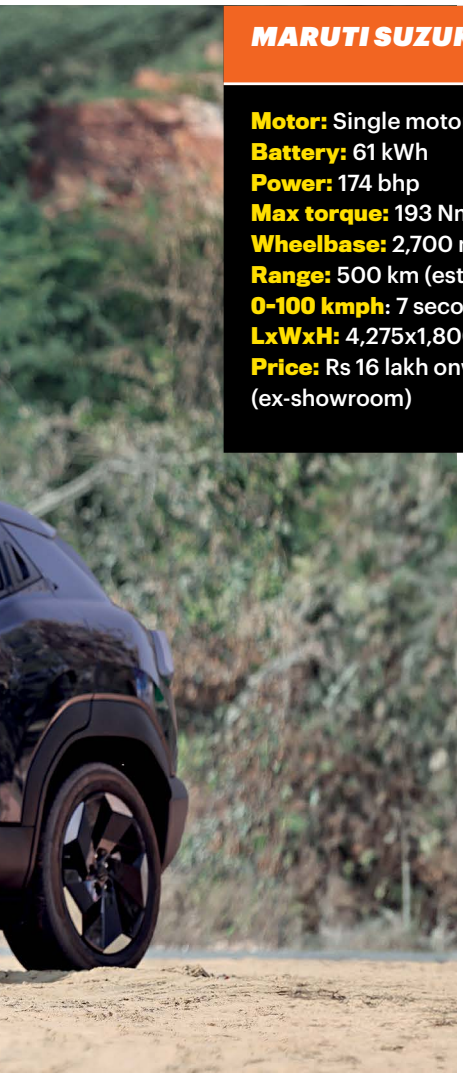


MARUTI SUZUKI

Motor: Single motor, FWD
Battery: 61 kWh
Power: 174 bhp
Max torque: 193 Nm
Wheelbase: 2,700 mm
Range: 500 km (est.)
0-100 kmph: 7 seconds
LxWxH: 4,275x1,800x1,640 mm
Price: Rs 16 lakh onwards (ex-showroom)

look very European. The dash houses the 10.2 inch infotainment system that operates various functions including battery regen options. The Infinity by Harman sound system operates via the same unit. The instrument panel is an all-digital affair and offers plenty of data. The centre console houses pleasingly retro toggle buttons in this otherwise digital age. Then there is a twin-deck console that houses the gear selector and functionalities like the wireless charger.

The seats are large and offer ample support, apart from being electrically adjustable and ventilated. Nothing alarming, but the low seat squab height makes one sit in a very knees-up position, which is aggravating. Thankfully, there is plenty of knee room.

The boot space is worth talking about. It offers 310 litres of flat, very usable cargo space. On the downside, the floor is a bit high. The rear seats are split well and, once folded, the e Vitara can take in 562 litres of cargo.

The e Vitara is based on the company's new HEARTECT-e platform. This skateboard houses the 61 kWh battery pack and the rest of the components.



So if you pop the hood of the e Vitara, it nearly seems like an engine! The e-axle sends power to the front wheels only and, as we said before, being conventional is key to the e Vitara's virtues. The motor churns out 174 bhp and 193 Nm of torque and this can propel the e Vitara to 100 kmph from zero in just 8.7 seconds. Top speed is rated at nearly 150 kmph. Maruti Suzuki has always had a target of ensuring that the e Vitara can traverse over 500 km on a charge and they are sticking to that.

The vehicle's drive calibration is on those lines as well. The initial two modes including Eco and Normal offer a very linear power delivery. It feels like one is driving a petrol/ diesel vehicle, just without the noise and vibrations. As the speed climbs, the e Vitara settles peacefully and can cruise at 100 kmph all day long. The NVH packing is good so very little noise enters the cabin. These two drive modes are out there to maximise efficiency but press the accelerator and they offer ample power to overtake. Switch to Sport mode and those who enjoy the violence and immediate power delivery of electric cars will be happy. The steering is well-weighted and offers ample feedback. Thanks to it being light, lock-to-lock turns are easy, so parking is easy. The 5.2 m turning radius will ensure turning the SUV is comfortable.

When it comes to suspension, the e Vitara feels very European. It is not stiff but absorbs well. Ruts and gravel stretches are no issue but once it hits a big pot hole, it does tend to thud into it. Bodyroll, though, is well controlled and we sure enjoyed pushing it into corners.

The story of the e Vitara is not just of the product but the infrastructure that the company is preparing for it. Thanks to the incredible number of touch points the company has, even if they put a charger in every station, India could truly be electrified. As for the e Vitara, the SUV offers a potent mix of features that should give most Indian car buyers pause for thought as they choose their next vehicle. Now all the company has to do is to price it right. ■